

(Here, the “11.0” is for Office 2003; for Office XP and Office 2000, it’s 10.0 and 9.0 respectively.)

Select the sub-key called Desktop, and there, create a new DWORD value called Show. Set it to 0. If you want to bring back that place, you’ll need to either delete the sub-key or (the smarter way of doing it) resetting it to 1.

Start or restart any Office program to see the changes.

Kill ‘em All!

If you’re like most people, you hate the Office assistants. Now, there’s an option within each Office program to stop using the Office assistant, but if you want to derive joy out of annihilating the Assistants, and do it for all Office programs in one go...

Navigate to:

HCU\Software\Microsoft\Office\11.0\Common\Assistant

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Delete *all* the DWORD values in that key. Yes, it sounds drastic, but that’s what you need to do. Clippy and the gang are now dead.

Hide The (Useless) Help Field

In every Office application, unless you’ve meddled around with some setting we don’t know of, you’ll see a space where you can “Type a question for help.” What’s the need for the bar when you can just press [F1]? In any case, it’s not fair that the bar should be there all the time, since we don’t use Help every single session. Remove it. Here’s how.

Navigate to:

HCU\Software\Microsoft\Office\11.0\Common\Toolbars\Settings